

External side effects and recovery

Project: Grounded Learning Service

1. Your mission

Your learning target

I can explain the mechanism and terminology of external side effects and recovery.

I can apply the stated procedure to a new case with a traceable result.

I can identify an assumption or limitation and design a revealing follow-up.

Remember before reading

Close your notes first. A rough first answer helps us choose the right starting point; it is not a score for your ability.

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Timeouts retries and cancellation. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Planning and action selection. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Failure budgets and service objectives. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

After trying, check the relevant lesson or ask your teacher. Change the part of your explanation that the evidence shows was wrong.

This week you will practise:

Explain the mechanism and terminology of external side effects and recovery

Apply the stated procedure to a new case with a traceable result

Identify an assumption or limitation and design a revealing follow-up

Retrieve what you already know

Recall Timeouts retries and cancellation. Explain why a recorded result needs its input conditions and evidence source before it can support a claim.

My starting explanation

This week's end goal

Explain external side effects and recovery using the deciding step in this fictional service.

2. Notice the evidence

External effects can succeed while their acknowledgement is lost. Recovery must inspect committed state before repeating the operation.

Begin by writing the question the procedure is intended to answer. Identify the information already supplied, the information it will produce and the information still missing. These are constructed classroom examples; they do not require live accounts, private records or an external service. Do not treat a plausible explanation as a measured outcome.

List the given facts and one fact that is not supplied.

3. See how it works

The mock ledger records prepared, committed or unknown per operation ID. Retry a committed operation by returning its result; reconcile unknown status instead of assuming failure. Preserve compensation as a separate authorised action.

External side effects and recovery — evidence trace

Input and scope · Check or calculation · Conclusion and limit

Input and scope: A booking is committed in storage, but response delivery times out. Caller asks to repeat.

Check or calculation: The mock ledger records prepared, committed or unknown per operation ID. Retry a committed operation by returning its result; reconcile unknown status instead of assuming failure. Preserve compensation as a separate authorised action.

Conclusion and limit: Lookup the operation ID and return the committed booking; do not create a second

booking. A lost acknowledgement does not undo the effect.

The figure connects this chapter’s worked input, declared procedure and result. Read the complete worked reasoning for qualifiers and intermediate steps; the abbreviated labels do not replace that reasoning.

Before applying the procedure, write its units, denominator or decision boundary where relevant. A partner should be able to repeat each step using the same inputs. If a required input is absent or violates the stated contract, record that condition explicitly instead of quietly replacing it with a convenient value.

Connect the picture and the explanation

Point to the input, the deciding step and the result in this week’s visual. Explain the same step in ordinary words. A picture helps when you can say what each part represents.

4. Compare the cases

Compare a familiar case with a changed case

A booking is committed in storage, but response delivery times out. Caller asks to repeat. Show the intermediate steps and give the conclusion with its scope.

Keep the procedure fixed. Explain what changed in the inputs and result.

Change one thing in the pictured case

Change: Status reliably reports J6 absent.

Prediction: A policy-approved resend using the same deduplication key may be considered.

Reason: Confirmed absence supplies different evidence from silence.

5. Words that unlock the idea

Word · Meaning

Word: Acknowledgement

Meaning: A response confirming operation status

Word: Reconciliation

Meaning: Checking authoritative state after uncertainty

Word: Compensation

Meaning: A separate action intended to offset a prior effect

Use two terms to explain a step in this week's example.

6. Follow a worked example

A booking is committed in storage, but response delivery times out. Caller asks to repeat.

Lookup the operation ID and return the committed booking; do not create a second booking. A lost acknowledgement does not undo the effect.

Compare the intermediate evidence with the final statement. Explain why each number or decision follows from the stated inputs. The conclusion belongs to this scenario and procedure; changing the inputs, evaluation population or authority can change what it establishes. Retain the raw record so a later revision can be compared honestly.

Learn from the worked case

Cover the result before checking it. Say what is given, choose the procedure, and follow one step at a time. Then uncover the result and explain your first mismatch. Ask why a step is allowed, not only what number it produces.

A pictorial worked case: External side effects and recovery

Recover an uncertain print job. A badge printer loses its reply after receiving a print request.

The facts we will use

Job key J6 identifies one badge. The printer supports status lookup by key; missing acknowledgement leaves outcome unknown.

External side effects and recovery

Start with the supplied facts

Follow each arrow. Ask which fact allows the next step.



1. Record uncertainty

Sending occurred, but printing completion is not yet known.



2. Query J6

Ask for the existing job's recorded state.



3. Recover from status

If complete, return that result without issuing another print job.

CHANGE ONE THING

Status reliably reports J6 absent.

Explain the changed result using the matching lesson.

Read the picture one step at a time

Step · What happens and why

Step: 1. Record uncertainty

What happens and why: Sending occurred, but printing completion is not yet known.

Step: 2. Query J6

What happens and why: Ask for the existing job's recorded state.

Step: 3. Recover from status

What happens and why: If complete, return that result without issuing another print job.

Match each pictured step to the supplied facts. This is a worked teaching case, not an independent assessment.

Why this result follows

A lost response does not show whether an external effect occurred. Recovery distinguishes unknown outcome from a confirmed failed action.

What this example does not establish

Without reliable status or deduplication, escalate uncertainty rather than claiming one and only one print.

7. Find and repair a mistake

A compensating action is itself a side effect requiring authority; recovery does not silently permit deletion or refund.

A useful check asks what would make the reasoning fail. Distinguish a failure to execute the declared procedure from a weakness in the procedure itself. The first may require a correction; the second requires an explicitly revised method and new evidence. Preserve unsuccessful cases so an improved result cannot hide the original problem.

Guided: restate the worked result, then name the assumption or limitation that prevents a broader conclusion.

Locate the earliest unsupported step

A report omits this qualification: A compensating action is itself a side effect requiring authority; recovery does not silently permit deletion or refund. Explain how omitting it could change a reader's interpretation, and write an accurate replacement.

State one repair and the checks you would rerun.

8. Practise together

Explain the weekly mechanism in your own words. Use the worked scenario to name its input, decision rule and output.

Guided: restate the worked result, then name the assumption or limitation that prevents a broader conclusion.

Explain your prediction to a partner before comparing results.

Practise with less help: Trace the worked case

Use workbook W2 for the connected example “External side effects and recovery”. First fill the input and rule boxes. Try the middle steps before asking for a hint. After a hint, try the next step yourself.

Plan · Do · Check

Plan: What is given? Which rule or procedure applies?

Do: Record each intermediate step.

Check: Does the result follow? What remains unknown?

Explain your trace to a partner. Your partner points to one step to check. Swap roles on the next case. Each person writes their own explanation.

Check your reasoning

Use the worked case for External side effects and recovery. Proposed explanation: “The worked result establishes every future case”. Decide whether this explanation is supported. Point to the step or supplied fact that decides; explain your repair if needed.

Answer on your own before discussion. If you are unsure, say which step you need help with.

Explain the picture

Distinguish a missing printer acknowledgement from confirmed failure. What should happen if J6 is complete, and what evidence changes when J6 is reliably reported absent?

My explanation using a pictured step and the given facts

This is supported practice. Keep the separately named independent case for an attempt before feedback.

9. Run the investigation

Predict, investigate and preserve the evidence

A booking is committed in storage, but response delivery times out. Caller asks to repeat. Show the intermediate steps and give the conclusion with its scope.

Record · Your evidence

Record: Given input and fixed rule

Your evidence: _____

Record: Prediction before checking

Your evidence: _____

Record: Actual result, or “not run”

Your evidence: _____

Record: First mismatch and one explanation

Your evidence: _____

Record: Boundary or missing input and expected response

Your evidence: _____

On paper, trace the supplied procedure. If code is provided, predict before running it in a local practice file. Never write an expected answer as though it were an observed run.

Plan → try → check

Before trying: what do I expect, and why? While trying: which step could first go wrong? Afterwards: what did I actually observe, and what should change? Keep “not run” if you only traced the procedure.

10. Build your understanding

Explain → apply → challenge

Explain the weekly mechanism in your own words. Use the worked scenario to name its input, decision rule and output.

A report omits this qualification: A compensating action is itself a side effect requiring authority; recovery does not silently permit deletion or refund. Explain how omitting it could change a reader's interpretation, and write an accurate replacement.

For the worked scenario, propose one additional case that could reveal a failure, describe its expected outcome before running it, and explain what would need to remain fixed for a fair comparison. Do not reuse W4 as a new final test after receiving feedback.

Explain which evidence supports your conclusion and which claim remains unproved.

11. Connect your project

Add a labelled external side effects and recovery evidence sheet to Grounded Learning Service. Show how you can explain the mechanism and terminology of external side effects and recovery. Use the supplied fictional case and keep its inputs, intermediate steps, calculation or prediction, and limitation. Connect this record to last week's record; a matching answer without a trace is insufficient.

Project evidence · Record

Project evidence: Component and version

Record: _____

Project evidence: Inputs permitted at prediction time

Record: _____

Project evidence: Trace and comparison with earlier work

Record: _____

Project evidence: Failure, limit and human review

Record: _____

Evidence for your project

For the Grounded Learning Service, retain an annotated trace and the changed-case result. Name the contract or evidence that makes the deciding step valid, so another team can review it.

12. Show what you know

Complete the supported workbook tasks before attempting W4 independently. Record any hints or help used. After feedback, use the teacher's fresh retry rather than copying the earlier answer. For a project, select a relevant new case, predict the outcome from the declared rule and preserve the result alongside any revision.

Exit: propose one revealing change to the worked scenario. State the expected outcome and the evidence that would make you revise your explanation.

For the worked scenario, propose one additional case that could reveal a failure, describe its expected outcome before running it, and explain what would need to remain fixed for a fair comparison. Do not reuse W4 as a new final test after receiving feedback.

My limited claim and a useful next check

13. Study a complete case

Complete evidence record

External side effects and recovery — evidence trace

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Conclusion and limit: Lookup the operation ID and return the committed booking; do not create a second booking. A lost acknowledgement does not undo the effect.

The figure connects this chapter's worked input, declared procedure and result. Read the complete worked reasoning for qualifiers and intermediate steps; the abbreviated labels do not replace that reasoning.

Follow the input through the stated procedure to its result. Cover the result first, predict it, then explain every intermediate step. The text/table accompanies the figure so the example can be read without colour.

My complete trace of the worked case

14. Try a new case independently

Independent case: Apply a new case independently

A payment-like classroom token transfer has unknown status after network loss. Should the mock repeat immediately?

My independent explanation, trace and limits

Attempt this case before feedback. Record any help. Earlier examples below are further practice; a case already practised with feedback cannot establish fresh transfer.

Attempt this without hints

A payment-like classroom token transfer has unknown status after network loss. Should the mock repeat immediately?

My independent procedure, result and limitation

Record support used: none, hint or teacher explanation. After feedback, a different case is needed to demonstrate independence.

Use feedback to improve

Attempt the independent case before hints. Record whether you worked alone, used a hint or followed a model. After feedback, fix the first unsupported step and explain why it changed. A later check uses a changed case, not a copied answer.